soldiers were seen on the Sikkimese side of the pass. After the first incursion in August, China issued a statement ‘refuting the rumours the Soviet Union fabricated in collusion with India that China had made “intrusion” into Sikkim’.[25] That was to become the standard line from the Chinese whenever there was an incident along the border—and there were many in the 1960s.

The Chinese, probably to annoy New Delhi, had also sent a condolence message on the death of Tashi Namgyal in 1963, and a congratulatory note on the April 1965 coronation of Thondup directly to Gangtok instead of forwarding it through the Indian government, which was responsible for Sikkim’s external relations. This was perceived as a recognition of Sikkim’s independence, and showed that China disapproved of Sikkim’s status as India’s protectorate.[26]

Only a few months after the coronation, war broke out between India and Pakistan. It had begun with a confrontation in Rann of Kutch in Gujarat in the beginning of the year, which ended with a ceasefire brokered by Britain in June. Likely encouraged by what Pakistan saw as a favourable outcome, about 30,000 Pakistani soldiers dressed as locals crossed the Line of Control in Kashmir in the first week of August. Fighting erupted with the Indian security forces who, for the most part, drove them back. Pakistan’s response was a massive attack on 1 September 1965 across the Line of Control in Kashmir and the bombing of Indian airfields in an offensive codenamed ‘Grand Slam’. But the belief that the Indian Army would crumble under the onslaught was short-lived. On 6 September, the Indian Army crossed the international border in Punjab and came within striking distance of Lahore.

The war witnessed some of the largest tank battles since World War II. The Indian Army had recovered from the defeat by China in 1962 and now had more men and weaponry. Although the Pakistan Army did occupy some positions inside India, Operation Grand Slam was not going as planned and expected. China had to come to the rescue by threatening to open a new front in Sikkim. If China could occupy a corridor between Tibet and East Pakistan via Sikkim, Darjeeling, and Siliguri, the entire northeastern region of India would be cut off from the rest of the country.

China began by sending protest notes to the Indian Embassy in Beijing, followed by an ultimatum on 16 September. It alleged that Indian troops